Aakaash K. Rao

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Employment

Department of Managerial Economics and Decision Sciences, Kellogg School of Management.

Assistant Professor, 2026-.

Donald P. Jacobs Scholar, 2026-2027.

Education

Department of Economics, Harvard University.

Ph.D. in Economics, 2020-2026.

The University of Chicago.

B.S., Mathematics and B.A., Economics (with honors), The University of Chicago, 2015-2018.

Research

Working Papers

"The Business of the Culture War" (with Shakked Noy)

Published and Forthcoming

"Polarisation and Public Policy: Political Adverse Selection under Obamacare" (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Jonathan Kolstad, Pietro Tebaldi, and Noam Yuchtman) — *The Economic Journal*, 2025. doi:10.1093/ej/ueaf079

"The Immigrant Next Door" (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Thomas Chaney, and Tarek A. Hassan) — *American Economic Review*, 114(2), February 2024, 348–384, doi:10.1257/aer.20220376

"Justifying Dissent" (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Georgy Egorov, Ingar Haaland, and Christopher Roth) — *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 138(3), August 2023, 1403–1451, doi:10.1093/qje/qjad007

"Opinions as Facts" (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Christopher Roth, and David Yanagizawa-Drott) — *Review of Economic Studies*, 90(4), July 2023, 1832–1864, doi:10.1093/restud/rdac065

Other Publications

Non Peer-Reviewed Publications

"Scapegoating During Crises" (with Leonardo Bursztyn, Georgy Egorov, Ingar Haaland, and Christopher Roth) — *American Economic Association Papers and Proceedings*, 2022

Statistical Software

"`starbility`: coefficient stability plots in R" (`https://github.com/AakaashRao/starbility`)

Teaching Experience

Teaching Fellow, Political Economy of Electoral Democracies (Harvard Economics, 2024-25)

Teaching Fellow, Advanced Intermediate Microeconomics (Harvard College, 2023-25)

Teaching Fellow, Political Economy of Non-Democracies (Harvard Economics, 2023)

Instructor, Senior Thesis Workshop (Harvard College, 2022-23)

Teaching Fellow, Topics in Political Economy (Harvard Economics, 2022)

Instructor, PhD Math Camp (Harvard Economics, 2022-25)

Stata/R tutor (Harvard College, 2020)

Teaching Fellow, Universidad Panamericana Summer Enrichment Program (University of Chicago, 2019)

College Core Tutor in Economics and Statistics (University of Chicago, 2017 – 2019)

Professional Activities

Presentations

2026: Stanford GSB, MIT, UC Berkeley, Institutions Organization and Growth, NBER Summer Institute (Political Economy), University of Southern California, University of Illinois Urbana-Champagne, Brookings Institution, Johns Hopkins, NYC Media Seminar

2025: SIEPR, Kellogg School of Management, CEPR Workshop on Media, Technology, Politics, and Society, Tallinn Workshop on the Economics of Advertising and Marketing, University of Cologne

2024: Consortium on the American Political Economy, Kellogg Political Economy of Ideas and Ideology Conference, Hebrew University of Jerusalem, Tel Aviv University

2023: ASSA, University of British Columbia

2022: ASSA, Barcelona School of Economics Summer Forum

2021: Harvard Experiments Conference, Uppsala Immigration Lab Conference, Early Career Behavioral Economics Conference, ECONtribute Summer Workshop

Referee Service

American Economic Review, American Economic Review: Insights, American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, American Economic Journal: Economic Policy, American Economic Journal: Microeconomics, Economic Journal, Economica, Journal of the European Economic Association, Journal of Political Economy, Journal of Public Economics, Journal of Urban Economics, Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, Quarterly Journal of Economics, Review of Economics and Statistics, Review of Economic Studies

Honors, Awards, & Fellowships

Institute for Humane Studies Junior Fellowship Award (2024-25)

Student Recognition of Teaching Award (2023-25)

Harvard Economics Pizza Oven Grant (2022)

Facebook Foundational Integrity and Impact Grant (2021)

Sloan Foundation Behavioral Economics Applications and Foundations Grant (2020)

Becker Friedman Institute Economic Effects of Coronavirus Grant (2020)

Pearson Institute for the Resolution of Global Conflicts Research and Innovation Grant (2020)

Institute for Humane Studies Free Speech and Open Inquiry Grant (2019)

J-PAL Governance Initiative Grant (2019)

University of Chicago Big Ideas Generator Grant (2019)

World Bank Research Grant (2019)

Pearson Institute for the Resolution of Global Conflicts Research and Innovation Grant (2019)

Last updated: July 27, 2026